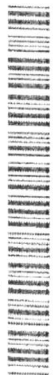


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Journal Title: Monsoon feelings : a history of
emotions in the rain /

Volume:

Issue:

Month/Year: 2018

Pages: 9-43.

Article Author: Imke Rajamani

Article Title: Monsoon Feelings: Introduction

Imprint: New Delhi, India : Niyogi Books, 2018.

Charge

Maxcost: 100.00IFM

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Monsoon Feelings

A History of Emotions in the Rain

Edited by

Imke Rajamani

Margrit Pernau

and

Katherine Butler Schofield

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Published by

NIYOGI BOOKS

Block D, Building No. 77,

Okhla Industrial Area, Phase-I,

New Delhi-110 020, INDIA

Tel: 91-11-26816301, 26818960

Email: niyogibooks@gmail.com

Website: www.niyogibooksindia.com

Text © Individual Authors

Images © As credited

Editor: Sucharita Ghosh

Design: Nabanita Das

ISBN: 978-93-86906-47-2

Publication: 2018

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Printed at: Niyogi Offset Pvt. Ltd., New Delhi, India

Pg 2: Monsoon clouds over the Bara Imambara, Lucknow, July 2016.

Photograph by Heiko Sievers.

Monsoon Feelings:

Introduction

Imke Rajamani



Figure 1: Monsoon scenery in Madhya Pradesh.

Photograph by Rajarshi Mitra, 2013.

Learning How to Feel the Monsoon

The monsoon is a season of strong wind, heavy rain and intense emotions in India. A fast wind blows from the Indian Ocean at the hottest point of the year. When it hits the South Asian subcontinent, heat radiating from the dry earth lifts the sea wind high into the atmosphere where it cools and releases its moisture from thick black clouds. Heavy rains drench and cool the lands from June throughout September, turning dried, cracked soil into lush green landscapes and fruitful fields.

The monsoon is a spectacle of nature. It is hard to believe that anyone could witness the massive clouds, pouring rains and colourful transformations in the flora without being in any way affected or moved by its force. For many, the monsoon is the season of fertility and joy. It signals the beginning of a new life cycle. For others, the rainy season brings despair and sorrow. Its floods and droughts cause hunger, disease and death. With every monsoon experience, one learns both to enjoy and fear the rainy season. The monsoon, then, is not just a seasonal weather condition, but also a lived social and cultural phenomenon. The immediate experience of wind and rain is thus not the only way of learning how one could and should

relate to the monsoon emotionally. Monsoon feelings have inspired the creation of many outstanding works of art over the centuries, through which an array of entangled emotions have been shared, taught and learned.

Meghaduta, 'The Cloud Messenger', by fifth-century Sanskrit poet Kalidasa, is one of the most famous and widely circulated poems on monsoon feelings.¹ A young man has been exiled from home. He is a *yaksha*, a nature-spirit and caretaker of nature's gardens in the service of the Lord of Wealth, Kubera. His banishment is his punishment for having neglected his master's garden, probably while he was enjoying romantic interludes with his young wife in the monsoon rains. Almost one year of loneliness and despair has passed, when the *yaksha* sees an elephant-shaped rain cloud hovering over his dwelling on a hill. The presence of the monsoon messenger raises his spirit and hopes. He approaches the cloud with flattering words to waft a message of love and longing to his wife:

जातं वंशे भुवनविदिते पुष्करावर्तकानं जानामि त्वां प्रकृतिपुरुषं कामरूप मघोनः । [...]
 संतप्तानां त्वमसि शरणां तत्त्वयोद प्रियायाः संदेशं मे हर धनपतिक्रोधविश्लेषितस्य ।

You, offspring of the world-renowned cloud family of the
Pushkaravartakas, servant and being of rain god Indra [...] You, refuge,
rescue and water for the parched, oh cloud, carry a message to my beloved
for me, as I am torn away by the wrath of the Lord of Wealth.²

The cloud halts. Maybe it is listening to the *yaksha*'s words? The young man describes to the cloud its path for the journey to deliver the message. In his poetic instruction, the beauty of the Himalayan landscapes during the rainy season comes to life:

rivers flow with the energy and grace of dancing women, mango trees yield ripe fruits, and wild elephants play in the forests. The air is full of the intoxicating fragrances of flowers and wet soil. The *yaksha* advises the cloud to enjoy the sensual pleasures of the erotically charged atmosphere. At the same time he reminds the cloud not to slow its journey too much or to forget its duties to expend monsoon feelings through raining, sounding and colouring the sky. The cloud must play the part of a thundering drum in the evening worship of Lord Shiva in the temple of Mahakal, where the devotees hail the monsoon clouds for their colour that matches the deep blue of Shiva's neck. If the cloud needs to rest, it should do so by spending gentle rain in the palaces of Alakapuri, where the beauty of the women, the colours of the flowers that decorate their braids, and the shine of their jewellery match the rainbow of Lord Indra, god of rains.

वक्रः पन्था यदपि भवतः प्रस्थितस्योत्तराशां सौधोत्सङ्गप्रणयविमुखो मा स्म भूर्ज्जयिन्याः ।
विध्युदामस्फुरितचक्रितैस्तत्र पौराङ्गनानां लोलपाङ्गर्ग्यदि न रमसे लोचनैर्वन्त्रितोऽसि ॥

Your path may become curved, yet be not averse to encountering the scenery on the roofs of the palace of Ujjain in the North. Your eyes would be treacherous, if the sight of the women's quivering eyes, trembling under your brilliant wreath of lightning, would not cause you lust and delight.³

Having enjoyed and expended monsoon pleasures, the messenger must then move on to find the *yaksha*'s house and garden. The cloud shall feed the garden fountain with new water, make the peacock dance, and awaken the creepers and flowers from the fatigue of summer heat. The cloud will find the *yaksha*'s wife in tears, her hair dishevelled, as she lies lonely on the bed and

dreams of the reunion with her beloved. Her body is overheated from the burning feelings of separation. With gentle sounds, a cooling breeze, and drizzling raindrops the *yaksha* imagines the cloud easing his wife's pains. The dream of her relief, joy and pleasure makes the *yaksha* delight in monsoon feelings himself. A wind blows and the cloud moves north.

The *yaksha* is a connoisseur and master of monsoon pleasures. The poem can be read as a lesson in monsoon sensuality. Did the cloud learn to feel and spend the sensual pleasures of the monsoon appropriately? The poem does not tell: whether the cloud took the recommended route, whether it learned to feel the monsoon, whether it aroused romantic feelings in the *yaksha*'s wife. But the history of the poem itself tells us that the voice of the *yaksha* taught many generations of readers, performers and audiences of Kalidasa's *Meghaduta* about the monsoon's manifold sensual pleasures. Copies, transcripts and translations into many Indian languages belonging to different centuries, as well as references to the *Meghaduta* in works by other poets, suggest that the poem has been circulating throughout the South Asian subcontinent for the better part of two millennia.



Figure 2: The *yaksha* instructs the messenger cloud.

Stamp from the Kalidasa commemorative stamps series, India Post, 22 June 1960.

It is not only Sanskrit scholars who have emphasised the poem's status as cultural heritage of national significance.⁴ Since the late nineteenth century, monsoon arts became increasingly nationalised. A 1960 stamp depicts the *yaksha* instructing the messenger cloud (see Figure 2). As a symbol of his message of love and longing the young man releases flower petals into the monsoon wind. A group of cranes seems to carry the message towards the raincloud and the logo

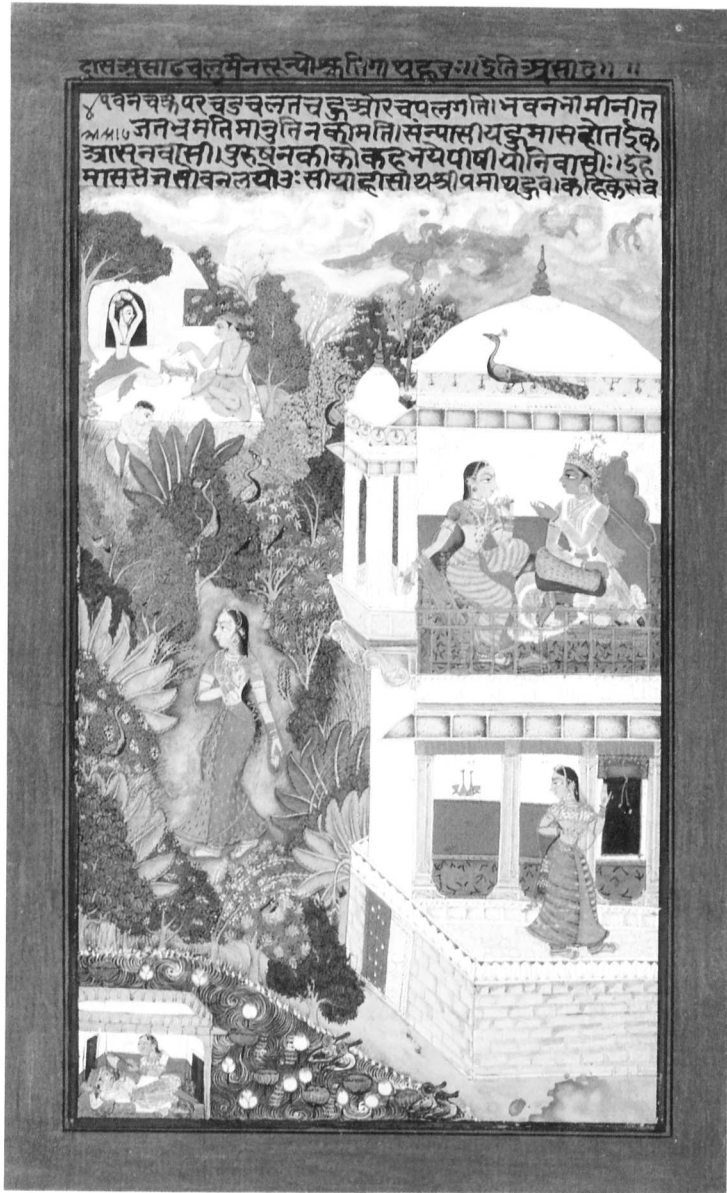


Figure 3: Month of Asadha. Folio from a *barahmasa* album, Kota, c. 1700–25.

Los Angeles County Museum of Art.

‘India postage’. A line from Kalidasa’s *Meghaduta* (*Purvamegha*, verse 2), adorns the bottom of the image: ‘On the first day of the month of Asadha, he saw a cloud over the forested mountain side, which looked like a playful elephant stooped to bunt the hills.’ The stamp was issued on the first day of the month of Asadha, the beginning of the monsoon season in the Sanskrit calendar, on 22 June 1960.

Kalidasa’s *Meghaduta* is one example of a canon of monsoon arts and symbols that are presented and perceived today as conveying the ‘naturalness and essence of Indian national culture’. Another example is the peacock, an essential symbol in monsoon arts, poetry and music, and India’s national bird, chosen for its ubiquity in Indian religions, legends, arts and traditions. The nationalisation of the monsoon is based on the image of the monsoon as a reliable, ‘unchanging friend’ (*bandhavo nirvikarah*)—to use Kalidasa’s expression from the *Ritusamhara*, a canonical poem on the characteristics of the seasons.⁵ The national image of the monsoon suggests that the eternal seasonal cycle has created a common realm of experience and attachment for all those who have lived on the soils of the Indian subcontinent past and present. The feelings that monsoon arts represent and elicit are taught to be feelings of national belonging; feelings of attachment to the soil and devotion to the clouds that water the fields; feelings of vitality and virility; feelings of longing and fulfilment.

At first glance, representations of the monsoon season in South Asian arts are characterised by striking consistencies and similarities. Certain motifs and symbolic structures characterise the ideal vision of the monsoon season across times, regions, media and genres. Young

women braving the elements to meet their lovers, amorous couples in the monsoon rain, sceneries of lush flora, mating peacocks and playful animals (see Figure 3) are consistent themes that can be traced from the pre-Vedic period to the present.⁶ Looking at these similarities, one might assume that the cyclical arrival of the season annually over thousands of years has always evoked the same monsoon feelings.

This book presents a different vision of the monsoon and the feelings associated with the rainy season: monsoon feelings have a history, which encompasses both continuity and change. The season comes every year, but when, where, and how much it rains differs between the years and regions. Meteorological data and writings show that the weather phenomenon has a vivid history that encompasses both long-term and annual patterns of change. The changing conditions have affected people and their culture. For example, the rise and decline of the Indus Valley Civilisation has been attributed to shifts in monsoon patterns.⁷ Historical sources also show that the monsoon has always elicited heightened emotions; but how exactly the rains or their absence was experienced has differed across time and region. To understand monsoon feelings, one has to ask: who experienced the monsoon, at which time, in which place, and through which cultural beliefs and practices?

The different and changing characters of monsoon feelings can be exemplified by how the monsoon is used to narrate and memorialise 15 August 1947—India's Independence Day. Khushwant Singh's novel *Train to Pakistan*, which is set during the rainy season of 1947, remembers a monsoon of fear, suffering and horror: the book narrates the communal violence that followed the partition of British

India into the hostile nation states of India and Pakistan. It begins with a delayed onset of the rains, when 'people began to say that God was punishing them for their sins'—sins of rape and murder committed during the political riots that occurred that summer. It rains heavily throughout the story, which evokes many atrocities committed in the names of nation and religion. The book concludes with a description of the dead bodies of murdered men, women, children and cattle floating in the river Sutlej that has been flooded by the monsoon.⁸ Singh's novel relates negative monsoon feelings to the birth of the Indian nation.

Not so the recent Hindi film *Lagaan* (2001), which also begins with a delayed monsoon. In this story, monsoon feelings of love and courage become the glue for an Indian nation based on communal harmony. In this symbolic framework, the formation of the Indian nation state is remembered as the fulfilment of nationalist longing for independence: just as the longed-for monsoon rains bring joy and relief from the scorching summer heat, independence brought joy and relief from British colonial rule.⁹ The novel and the film present two contrasting interpretations of how the monsoon relates emotionally to the Indian nation. A reader of Singh's novel, or those who were affected by the kind of violence he describes, will probably have different feelings when the rains start, compared with the viewer of *Lagaan*, who walks out of the cinema and into the rain with a spring in her step.

In this book we investigate the particularly rich, diverse, and changing history of monsoon feelings from the twelfth century to the present. We establish a dialogue between different arts and traditions

with a focus on the northern and western regions of the South Asian subcontinent. We explore how the monsoon has been experienced by writers and readers, musicians and their audiences, painters and those who look at miniatures, garden architects and the courtly users of their creations, producers of films and movie-goers, doctors and their patients, and those who rely on medical, religious and folk knowledge for their daily life.

The monsoon and the emotions associated with it have been shaped and changed by ongoing processes of migration, translation, integration, transformation and transcultural conflation. The word *monsoon* itself originates from the Arabic *mausam*, meaning season. Arab sailors deciphered the monsoon winds a millennium ago and used them to connect the Mediterranean and the Indian Ocean ports on the seasonal route of a fast ‘trade wind’.¹⁰ So reliable was this airy vehicle that the great fifteenth-century Arab navigator Ibn Majid ‘saw the monsoon above all as a specific *date* for sailing from a port’.¹¹ Arabs, Ottomans, Gujaratis, Tamils, Achenese, Malays and Chinese knew how to interpret and use the monsoon winds for their endeavours in traversing the seas. With trade came religious pilgrimage and mission, diplomats and conquerors, new food items and fine goods, languages and literatures to South Asia. The monsoon winds were the natural mediators of these intercultural encounters that were both violent and culturally enriching, causing suffering and joy—just like the monsoon rains.

How does the Monsoon Feel Today?

While the discovery of the seasonality and directions of the monsoon winds is a long-standing historical achievement, the monsoon rains

remain unpredictable until today. In the months of May and June the interpretation of scientific records and meteorological data becomes a highly emotional issue. The daily updates of the monsoon maps from the Indian Meteorological Department are top news that people watch with anticipation and anxiety. Monsoon news reports on TV, radio and in newspapers are usually 'tinged with drama'.¹² Before the monsoon rains arrive, news reports focus on stories of suffering, fear and hope. They colour the mood of the people for whom the beginning and intensity of the rainfall will decide whether loss or fortune will accompany them for a year.

The start of the rain marks the beginning of the agricultural year and the economic cycle depending on the crops. But it is not only for farmers and traders that the amount of rainfall determines if the following twelve months will be prosperous or a time of hardship. Today, local amounts of rain have wide-ranging effects on the national economy as a whole. An average and evenly showering monsoon usually delivers good harvests and lower prices of basic commodities, higher rural demand, a boost to growth, low inflation, and lower interest rates. Extreme weather—for which the capricious monsoon is feared—can easily result in recession. The Indian stock-market figures from May and June reflect weather forecasts as at no other time of the year.¹³

Every monsoon poses again the threat of droughts and floods that can hit some regions and its people hard and without warning. How many deaths will the heat wave in Telangana cause until the clouds bring relief? Will there be rain at all in southern Maharashtra this year? Will the rain in Rajasthan be enough to make the crops

grow and feed the cattle? Will the monsoon flood Mumbai again, bringing traffic to a halt, constraining the mobility of people and goods, making houses uninhabitable, and causing disease especially among the urban poor? Should policy makers prepare for a monsoon catastrophe or wait for the forecast to estimate the risk? Will the government classify the weather condition as natural disaster to release relief funds for victims of droughts and floods? Will monsoon effects and feelings decide the next elections again, pushing the ruling party out of power or strengthening its position?

Predicting the monsoon rains is of utmost humanitarian, agricultural, political and economic importance in India. A great number of publications and research programmes are dedicated to estimating expected seasonal rainfalls. Yet the monsoon remains a mystery.¹⁴ It is probably the mysterious nature of the monsoon that elicits emotions even in the most scientifically minded. In his travelogue *Chasing the Monsoon*, Alexander Frater quotes a meteorologist named Julius Joseph in Trivandrum waiting anxiously for the monsoon to make its first landfall:

‘The monsoon itself is a creature of such grandeur and complexity that it defies comparison with anything.’ He smiled and touched his heart. ‘This is where it starts. When Delhi calls us, in the days leading up to it, they often ask how we feel...Predicting the burst is not just a matter of dry figures and charts. As it approaches you begin to feel elated, even slightly intoxicated. Maybe it has something to do with charged particles in the air; I don’t know. But only the foolish forecaster ignores his emotions.’¹⁵

This quotation shows most vividly that understanding the monsoon is not just a matter of studying weather records. It also means exploring how people in South Asia experience the rainy season emotionally. Anxiety, hope and feelings of intoxication did not become monsoon feelings only recently with the realisation of the limits of modern science in predicting the rains. The meteorologist, who speaks so passionately about the monsoon, is probably less moved by 'charged particles in the air' than the cultural context in which his life and work are embedded. Numerous songs, poems, paintings and movies from different stages in history describe the hopes and anxieties of anticipating the monsoon, and the intoxication one feels when the first raindrops hit soil and skin—though the protagonists here are usually not scientists, but lovers.

Monsoon fears and sufferings are dominant themes in the news media. *The Times of India* recently added the 'monsoon blues' to the repertoire of negative monsoon feelings: a newly identified 'seasonal affective disorder' caused by 'muggy and gloomy' weather and constrained mobility.¹⁶ In contrast, popular movies and wedding photographs are examples of media that keep up the tradition of celebrating the monsoon as a season of joy, love and romance. The pictures of Krishna and Radha strolling in the rain (Figure 4) and the photograph of a bridal couple (Figure 5) illustrate that the monsoon feelings that we encounter in today's media are always evoked with the help of shared and historically grown aesthetics. The motif of lovers romancing under the umbrella in the rain is a familiar one in the Indian arts since at least the eighteenth century. The Hindi film *Shree 420* from 1955 and a photograph made on its set of India's most romantic screen



Figure 4: Monsoon feelings under the umbrella in the past: Krishna and Radha strolling in the rain, Jaipur, 1775.

Los Angeles County Museum of Art.

Figure 5: Monsoon feelings under the umbrella in the present: bridal couple.

Photograph by Lin and Jirsa Photography, 2016.



couple, Raj Kapoor and Nargis (Figure 61 in this book), made this motif even more iconic. Today many wedding albums of Indian couples feature a photograph of bride and groom in a similar pose. Monsoon romance under the umbrella is a conventional emotion and consistent artistic theme. And yet it does not fail to elicit and express individual feelings. The photograph of the happy couple (Figure 5) may borrow its notion of a divine emotional moment from Krishna and Radha, allude to the timeless Bollywood romance of Nargis and Raj Kapoor, and at the same time express the personal romantic feelings of the bride and the groom for each other. Monsoon love feels special and can thus not be reduced to historically grown social convention. But even when monsoon feelings appear mysterious, magical and timeless today, these emotional moments are never created outside history.

How did the Monsoon Feel in the Past?

Feelings are not an easy subject to research in history. Many people today consider emotions to be subjective. According to this perception, feelings arise in a person's inner self—in the soul, in the heart, in the brain. Emotional expressions may poorly represent to the outside world the feelings a person has inside.¹⁷ Moreover, emotions seem to be ephemeral. A feeling can last for seconds, maybe a year, or even a life time, but it certainly seems to vanish with the death of the person who experienced it. The complex methods developed and used by psychologists and psychiatrists today to access the interior world of their clients show that investigating emotions is a difficult task even in the presence of the feeling person. How can we learn about people's emotional experiences of the monsoon season in history—feelings of people who lived and died decades and centuries ago?

In their search for emotions, the first move of historians is often to look for texts in which people expressed their personal interior feelings, preferably in letters or diaries. Unfortunately this approach does not work for all projects in the history of emotions. Texts that were meant to express or document personal feelings were not common to all cultures and communities in the past and present. Even the idea that emotions were divided into authentic interior feeling and incomplete exterior expressions cannot be taken as a given. In several literary traditions of South Asia prior to the nineteenth century, authors treated emotions rather as stemming from social interactions and communication, something not enclosed *inside an individual*, but that arises only and functions *between persons*.¹⁸ A prominent example is the nine *rasas*, the emotional

essences of aesthetic production and experience, described in the c. two-thousand-year-old treatise *Natyashastra* by Bharata Muni, and in many later interpretations and extensions of his text. The idea of *rasa* has a vivid theoretical and performative history.¹⁹ In this theory, key emotions are produced as essences or flavours (*rasa*) from the interactions between performers and audiences, as well as the aesthetic interplay of gestures, sounds, colours and temperature. The *rasas* take coherent shape in a space between people as an essence, which is simultaneously created and ‘tasted’ with all the senses. Those involved in the interaction contribute and react to the formation of *rasa* through bodily states of feelings, the *bhavas*. Yet, according to texts by Bharata Muni and his commentators the function of *rasa* is to mediate between people and create a shared emotional mood, rather than to elicit individual feelings.²⁰

Recent studies in the history of emotions have suggested ways of investigating feelings without relying on first-person confessions. They assume that emotions can be simultaneously individual and social, personal and conventional, based on cultural traditions and yet malleable. Thus all media and cultural artefacts—from language to works of art to music—which people use to arouse, express, experience, and share their feelings are potential sources that provide evidence for historical emotions. They contain traces of feelings that people experienced long ago.²¹ In this book we attempt to approach multiple artistic media without imposing our contemporary understanding of emotions and related categories. We seek to avoid making dualistic distinctions between body and mind, inner and outer, emotions and rational thought, which have dominated European philosophies and sciences at least since the

Enlightenment.²² We rather try to understand how the historical actors themselves conceptualised the rainy season, the body and emotions. We investigate their knowledge to ask how people thought about and felt the monsoon in the past. In other words, we explore the monsoon as an *emotion concept*.

Concepts can best be understood as nodes in a network of knowledge, feelings and memories that we use to evaluate situations we encounter and to navigate through the world. Scholars in the history of concepts have long concentrated their research on keywords and highlighted the importance of language in structuring human thinking and their resultant behaviour. Investigators in the neurosciences and in the humanities have discovered that thinking and feeling are not clearly separable processes. They speak of ‘cogmotion’ to argue that cognition and emotion inform each other, involving not only language but stimuli from all senses.²³ For example, to understand the concept of love it is not enough to read philosophical texts in which love is defined, explained and morally evaluated. One would also have to ask: how does love look, smell, taste and sound? A new approach suggests we research concepts beyond language. Emotion concepts can be approached as multimedia networks of meaning that link not only words, but also images, sounds, smells, tastes and tactile impressions that people get from their environment and various media. The multimedia semantics of emotion concepts indicate how feelings were practised and thus how they could have been experienced in the past.²⁴

This book arose from a conference held at the Max Planck Institute for Human Development in Berlin in June 2015, in which experts

on Indian art, architecture, literature, religion, music, film, medicine and history came together to explore the *concept of monsoon feelings* from different times and cultural contexts within South Asia. During the conference the monsoon revealed itself to be a fascinating theme that captured multiple, even seemingly opposing, feelings in its semantic net. While some images, sounds, symbols or narrative patterns remained consistent or similar across time, genres, cultures and languages, others were subject to translation and change. How did the monsoon as a weather condition and in sensing bodies, multiple arts and media, and emotional practices shape and change monsoon feelings?

The monsoon is first of all a *material reality* of nature. Certain trees blossom in the seasonal climate, such as the scarlet-coloured gulmohar or the yellow monsoon cassia. The fragrances of cape jasmine and hibiscus add to the beauty of the gardens. The pied-crested cuckoo²⁵ and other migratory birds appear during the monsoon, enriching the natural soundscape of thunder and raindrops with their sounds and songs. And so do the croaking frogs and crying peacocks (see Figure 6). Humans connect to this material reality through their bodies and all the senses. With our eyes we see the dark clouds approaching, with our ears we hear the cuckoo's song, our noses register the unique monsoon smell of wet soil, and finally we sense the wetness of the raindrops on our skin.

All these natural bodily sensations would not be important to us and elicit no particular feelings, if they were not part of a cultural repertoire through which we learned how to interpret them. Those who grew up with South Asian tales tune their ears to

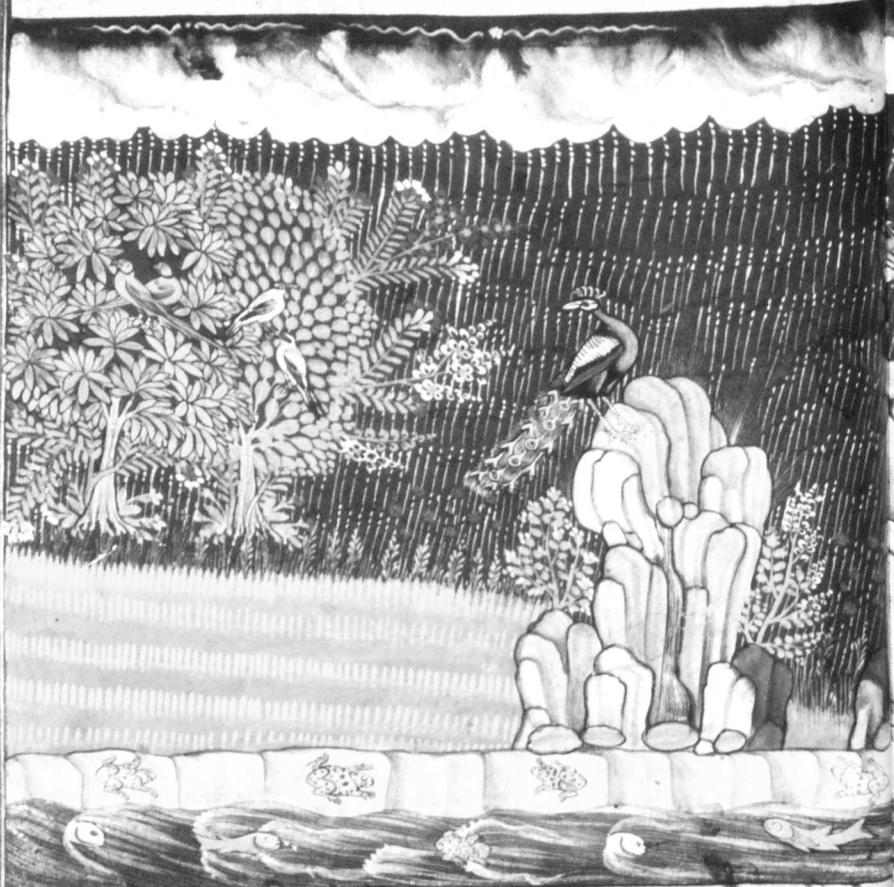
detect the sound of the cuckoo, because they learned to read the presence of the *chatak* as a sign of hope that the rains would begin soon. Folk knowledge in South India tells that seeing wild crinum lilies is an unmistakable sign of the arrival of the monsoon, as the flowers are believed to come into bloom exactly one week before the rainclouds burst. People living in the North Indian countryside smell the first drops of the monsoon as *saundhabhat* or *saundhi mahak*, the scent of wet clay soil, which many interpret as eliciting a pleasurable sense of freshness. These examples show that the way we hear, see and smell the monsoon and its natural harbingers is already influenced by cultural knowledge and beliefs.

It is through *interpretations* that we endow our bodily sensations with meaning. Making sense of what we feel is a highly creative and complex process of cogmation. As a kind of translation, the interpretation of our sensations alters both our senses and the concepts we use to make sense of what we feel. For example, when we experience the smell of the wet soil as the pleasures of *saundhi mahak*, we learn to tune our noses to detect this smell and enjoy it again. With every sensual experience of the monsoon our embodied knowledge about the season gets enriched, conforming to or altering the concept we have in mind. Enjoying or fearing the monsoon is thus learned emotional behaviour. Think of a foreign traveller in India, to whom the dark monsoon clouds announce an uncomfortable shower and might look overwhelmingly frightening. She would probably try to avoid the ‘bad weather’ and stay in the hotel. But to the audience of Indian monsoon songs, poetry and movies the clouds could signal the beginning of the season of lovers. Young couples meet in the wild or on the beach to enjoy the

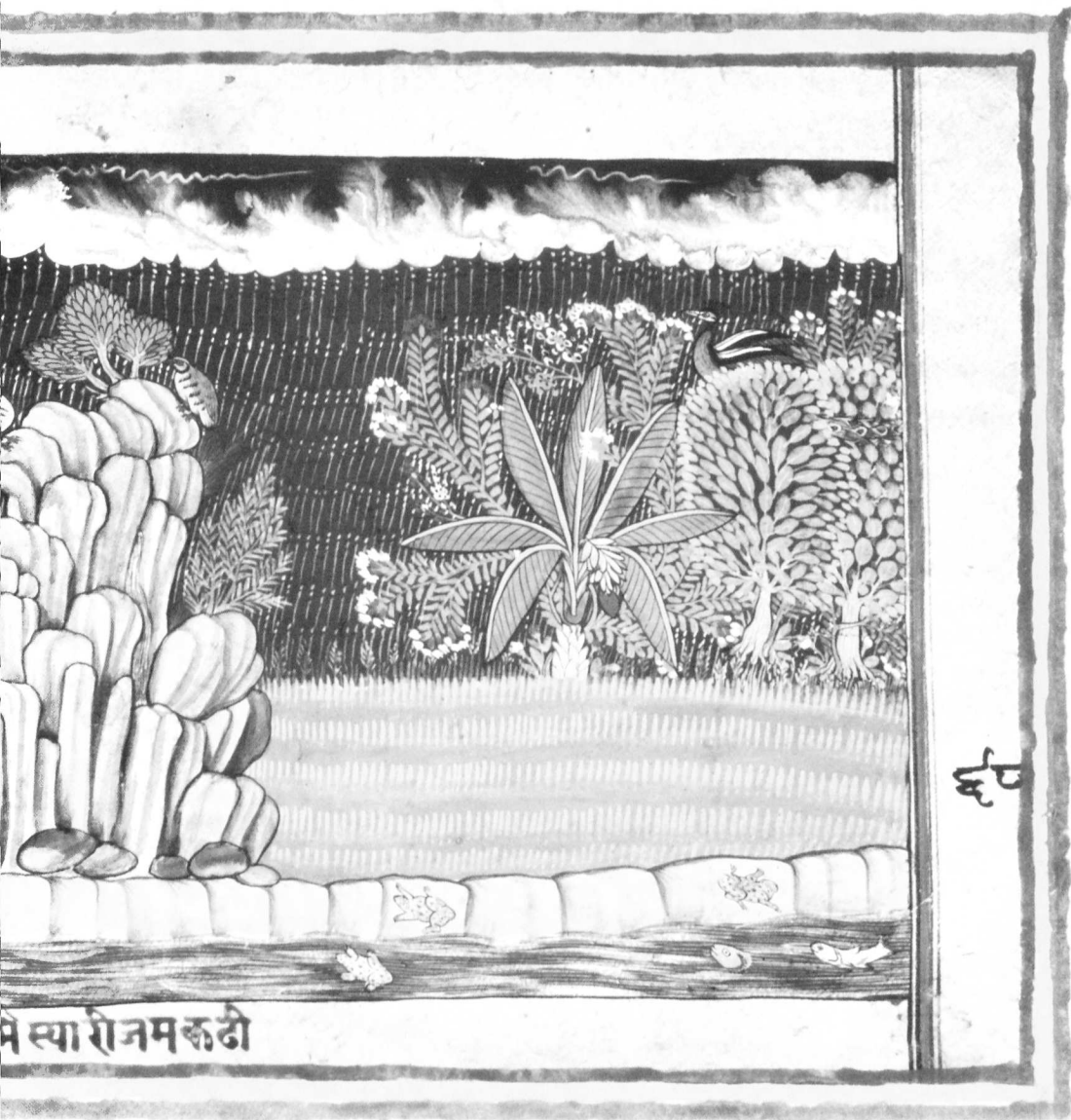
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Figure 6: The rainy season. Page from a series of illustrations to the *Bhagavata Purana*, Mewar, Rajasthan, c. 1630–50.
Philadelphia Museum of Art.

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वरसाहोहो पवननपवैठपछोबोलत जमुनाकिनारेबे



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spectacular scenery of clouds and feel the first drops of rain together. According to Bollywood movies, nothing can be more romantic and sexy than getting drenched in the monsoon rains.

Monsoon feelings not only arise through bodies being in touch with nature, but also by people sharing their feelings and thoughts about the monsoon through words and songs, in rituals or paintings. Indian perfume-makers have even found a way to elicit monsoon feelings throughout the year. *Mitti attar*, distilled by manufacturers in the city of Kanauj in Uttar Pradesh, is said to evoke the scent and associated feelings when the first drops of monsoon rain fall onto Indian clay soil.²⁶ Through experiencing objects and media that preserve qualities of the monsoon, *monsoon feelings* can arise in any season.

The monsoon has inspired many people in South Asia to share their own and record other people's feelings in artistic productions. Actually experienced monsoon feelings shaped the tunes of songs, were reflected in poetry, were the reason for building particular architecture and informed romantic movies. At the same time, *cultural styles* and *social conventions*, mediated through the creation, performance and consumption of art, informed people how the monsoon should be felt. Norms and conventions indicate the boundaries of monsoon feelings in a certain time and place. They also point towards the social conditions that catered for differing emotional experiences of the monsoon. Did men and women experience the monsoon in the same manner? How did the monsoon feel for a king, how for his servant? Who was allowed to take part in the monsoon celebrations and who were those excluded? How did religious beliefs and sentiments inform the experience of the

Figure 7: Monsoon scenery on Marina Beach in Chennai.

Photograph by Heiko Sievers, 2011.



monsoon? Despite the differences in feeling the monsoon, emotions related to the rainy season appear as a realm of experience that connects people that lived in different times, different regions, and belonged to different cultural, religious and social contexts.

Monsoon media interrelate—and so do monsoon feelings. For example, popular films evoke folk tales and poetry; poems describe the beauty of a garden; garden architecture is inspired by paintings; and *ragamala* paintings depict musical modes and the emotions associated with them. In many media and genres of Indian art, language, images, sounds, smells and shapes are inseparable, as they together form the multisensory stimulation the artists used to engage their audiences. Hence exploring the emotion concept of the monsoon through *intermediality* can help us to understand

how people in the past experienced the rainy season through a multisensory repertoire and shared knowledge about how to interpret it.

Poems, songs and paintings are not just representations or documentations of monsoon feelings in the past. They are also artefacts of *emotional practices*, things and techniques that people used to experience particular emotions, elicit them in others, or to give their feelings a certain quality of immediacy. 'Emotions are something that we do, not just have.'²⁷ Monsoon feelings arise through writing or reciting a poem, dancing and singing in the rain, flying on the swings in a monsoon garden, or simply by attending to one's feelings while watching the clouds. Looking at practices of anticipating the rains, celebrating their arrival, and dealing with the dangers of the season discloses how people created concepts, shaped the material reality around them, and altered their bodies in order to experience the monsoon in a certain manner. For example, poets and painters created pointed concepts in language and images through which the beauty and pains of the monsoon became graspable. When kings ordered the building of lake palaces or gardens that accommodated swings, fountains and sheltering pavilions, they shaped the material reality around them in order to enhance the pleasurable experience of the monsoon.²⁸ Doctors of Unani and Ayurveda medicine advised people how to alter their bodies through diets and exercises in order to make them resistant to the diseases that the monsoon climate could bring. These examples show that people have translated their knowledge about the rainy season—its perceived dangers and pleasures—into artistic, political, social and medical practices. Emotional practices build the connections between the

human body, the monsoon as a material weather condition, and the monsoon as a mediated cultural phenomenon.

Longings and Fulfilments

The history of the monsoon in South Asia is one of various connected longings and fulfilments—longings and fulfilments in the plural, to emphasise that the artistic translations of monsoon feelings between different media, genres and languages reflect difference and change, as much as similarity.

The first three chapters of the book concentrate on monsoon feelings in different genres of poetry. Sunil Sharma explains the meanings of love and war in Indo-Persian poetry from the twelfth to the fourteenth century, analysing a spectrum of monsoon feelings. On one end are gentle descriptions of longing. In this mode, longing is not confined to lovers, but also mediates the relationships between father and son, poet and patron, and friends. On the other are the forceful, martial emotions. Here the thundering monsoon clouds become violent or compare in their grandeur to the military prowess of a king. The thundering war clouds that feature in Indo-Persian poetry, though, have no place in the monsoon poetry composed by members of the Radhavallabhi community in the eighteenth century. Richard Williams discloses the foregrounding of gentleness and beauty in the verses composed in the Brajbhasha language. For the members of this Hindu sect, the monsoon mediates their devotional feeling of longing for Krishna's consort Radha. The Radhavallabhi community sang the poems to evoke among themselves the pleasurable feeling of getting soaked in love and devotion, just as the divine couple Radha and Krishna gets drenched as they romance in

monsoon rain. And the garden had swings, which invited young women to play, not only on the day of the monsoon festival of Teej. The setting of the garden, in which music was frequently heard, was perfect for romance and erotic play.

Longing and fulfilment could also be a less erotic and more pious way of feeling. Katherine Schofield and David Lunn reconstruct the almost-forgotten Rag Gaund, a musical mode closely associated with the monsoon, through its poetical, sonic and visual forms. At his eighteenth-century Mughal court, Shah 'Alam II composed several verses to be sung in Gaund to cultivate delight and devotion. The musical monsoon figurations in these songs elicited spiritual feelings of longing and fulfilment. But how might such a musical monsoon experience actually feel, how might it be created, in the body? To answer this question, Laura Leante interviewed and observed present-day musicians. In their performances, voluminous clouds and cooling rains are formed through musical sounds, movements and gestures. Musical performance evokes the semantics and feeling structures of the monsoon through the logic of intermediality, in which a little signifier brings a range of monsoon images and poetry to mind, such as the musical imitation of the mating cry of the *papiha* bird.²⁹ The '*piyu piyu*' of the hawk-cuckoo appears in songs of the Radhavallabhis, Persian poetry and *barahmasas* alike, as it sounds like a longing '*piya piya*': 'come my love'. In a similar manner, the musical imitation of the peafowls' mating cry evokes the many paintings where the bird is part of a scene in which the *nayika* waits for her lover, or a couple romances in the rain. Again *viraha* and its fulfilment in romantic love appear at the centre of a spectrum of feelings that musicians aim to feel and convey.

Monsoon songs are among the most popular from Bollywood. Rachel Dwyer explains how monsoon love has been translated in Hindi films from a feeling associated with nature, to an urban emotion. Mega-cities like Bombay can be frustrating to negotiate when streets get flooded, traffic comes to halt, and people get drenched on their way to work. But through the images of film couples getting drenched on Marine Drive, discovering their mutual feelings of love while coming close under the umbrella, or sharing a private moment in the car while the sounds and streams of rain on the windows shield them from the world around them, popular movies open up the possibility of seeing the metropolis during the monsoon as a romantic place. Is romance in Hindi films solely escapist fare, aimed at drowning the violence of the monsoon? Imke Rajamani addresses the political implications of monsoon feelings in two popular Hindi films that both have the violence of failing monsoons and the life threatening consequences of drought as their narrative contexts. Here, monsoon feelings of love, trust, courage, longing and belonging are used to construct appropriate feelings of gender and national identity. The two films pose examples of the concept of the monsoon being laden with ideas of authentic Indianness and moral culture being defined through its natural balance. The essay proposes a cinematic rainmaking formula, which deconstructs the vision of the authentic Indian nation by questioning the morality of emotions.

Claudia Preckel describes a rather unbalanced relation between people and the rainy season in her chapter on perceptions of the monsoon in Unani medical writings. Authors from this Islamic medical tradition were concerned that the monsoon climate caused an abundance of yellow bile in the human body. The imbalance

would cause disease, which nineteenth- and twentieth-century texts proposed to remedy by means of diets and herbal medicines. The medical discourse testifies to the fears of illness that the humid climate of the monsoon causes. In Unani literature, the monsoon is actually the most dangerous of all seasons. The essay suggests that medical practices have been central emotional practices during the monsoon—following a diet, taking the right measures of hygiene, or using medicines that would prevent digestion problems and skin diseases would have a big impact on whether the monsoon would be experienced as a season of suffering and disease, or as a season of joy, romance and beauty. Emotional practices to enjoy the monsoon are central in Margrit Pernau's historical account of the excessive celebrations of the *Phulwalon ki sair*. 'The flower-sellers' festival, which is celebrated today as a national festival in October, was a monsoon celebration in the nineteenth- and early-twentieth centuries. In processions that led from Delhi to the shrines, temples and wild gardens surrounding Mehrauli, men, women and *hijras* (South Asia's third gender), Muslims and Hindus, courtiers and common people came together. As they left behind courtly etiquette and social restrictions inside the city walls, people practised the fulfilment of their longings in excessive celebrations of joy, love and eroticism, as well as devotion and piety.

Vidya Rao concludes the book by sharing her own experiences of monsoon feelings as a performer of *thumri*, a form of Hindustani classical music. The essay relates the historically grown form of *thumri* to the moment of the performance. She tells how the *jhoola*, the swing-song, brings the body, thoughts and feelings into a swinging experience—light and heavy, up and down. The

performance stimulates all the senses of the singer and the audience. Rao also describes the ambiguity of monsoon feelings that she experiences during a performance. The same line of one song can be interpreted in many different ways and thus elicits many different feelings in the singer and her listeners. With every performance and every new experience the emotional meaning of a song can change. And so Rao also notes how being part of the Monsoon Feelings conference and book project changed her understanding of monsoon feelings in a particular song. The title of her essay, 'A Meeting of Earth and Sky', is a metaphor for the monsoon as a season in which seeming opposites become connected.

In the monsoon and its arts, beauty and ugliness, life and death, joy and sorrow, hope and despair, gentleness and excess, relief and threat are closely intertwined. Monsoon feelings are at the core of the rainy season: they are rich, diverse, ambiguous, and compelling. Join us as we explore their histories.

Endnotes:

1. I thank Frederik Schröer for assisting me with interpreting the *Meghaduta*. The translations from Sanskrit into English in this chapter are his.
2. Kalidasa and Charanatirtha Maharaj, *Meghadūtām: With the Kātyāyāni Sanskrit Commentary and English Translation*, Kashi Sanskrit Series, 219 (Varanasi: Chowkhamba Sanskrit Series Office, 1973), verses 6 and 7.
3. Ibid., verse 29.
4. Ibid., Introduction.
5. Kalidasa and M.R. Kale, *The Rtusambhāra by Kālidāsa* (Delhi: Motilal Banarsidass Publishers, 1967), verse 28.
6. For an extensive account and analyses of the monsoon in ancient South Asia see Gautama V. Vajracharya, *Frog Hymns and Rain Babies: Monsoon Culture and the Art of Ancient South Asia* (Mumbai: Marg Foundation, 2013).

7. Martin Menski, 'Monsoon', in *Key Concepts in Modern Indian Studies*, ed. Gita Dharampal-Frick, et al. (Delhi: Oxford University Press, 2015), 174–175.
8. Kushwant Singh, *Train to Pakistan* (New York: Grove Press, 1981 [1956]).
9. For a detailed analysis of monsoon nationalism in *Lagaan* see my chapter in this volume.
10. Alexander McAdie, 'Monsoon and Trade Winds as Rainmakers and Desert Makers', *Geographical Review* 12.3 (1922): 412–419.
11. Sunil Amrith, *Crossing the Bay of Bengal: The Furies of Nature and the Fortunes of Migrants* (Cambridge, MA: Harvard University Press, 2013).
12. Greg O'Hare, 'The Indian Monsoon, Part 2: The Rains', *Geography* 82.4 (1997): 335–352.
13. K.R. Saha, D.A. Mooley, and S. Saha, 'The Indian Monsoon and its Economic Impact', *GeoJournal* 3.2 (1979): 171–178; T.K. Velayudham, 'Monsoons and the Economy', *Economic and Political Weekly* 22.49 (Dec. 5, 1987): 2108–2111.
14. Jagadish Shukla, 'Monsoon Mysteries', *Science* 318.12 (2007): 204–205.
15. Alexander Frater, *Chasing the Monsoon* (New Delhi: Penguin Books India, 1991), 39.
16. Meghna Mukherjee, 'Are you Feeling the Monsoon Blues?' *The Times of India Online*, July 22, 2014, <<http://timesofindia.indiatimes.com/life-style/health-fitness/health-news/Are-you-feeling-the-Monsoon-Blues/articleshow/38801187.cms>>.
17. For the scholarly version of the argument see William M. Reddy, *The Navigation of Feeling: A Framework for the History of Emotions* (Cambridge: Cambridge University Press, 2001).
18. For the intervention see Margrit Pernau, 'Mapping Emotions, Constructing Feelings: Delhi in the 1840s', *Journal of the Economic and Social History of the Orient* 58 (2015): 634–667.
19. On the *rasa* and its history see Sheldon Pollock, *A Rasa Reader: Classical Indian Aesthetics* (New York: Columbia University Press, 2016).
20. Bharata, *The Nāṭya Śāstra: Translated into English by a Board of Scholars*, 2. rev. ed., Rāga nṛtya Series 2 (Delhi: Sri Satguru, 2000).
21. One of the most important interventions in the history of emotions with regard to challenging previous methods and binaries was posed by Monique Scheer, 'Are Emotions a Kind of Practice (and is That What Makes Them Have

- a History)? A Bourdieuan Approach to Understanding Emotion', *History and Theory* 51.2 (2012): 193–220.
22. The facultative distinction between body and mind, feeling and thinking is called the 'Cartesian Dualism', after the French philosopher René Descartes, whose *Meditations of First Philosophy* (1641) was a highly influential text in the Enlightenment movement and the sciences that became institutionalised thereafter.
 23. Douglas Barnett and Hilary Ratner were the first to propose the term 'cogmotion' to argue that thinking and feeling are not separate processes; Douglas Barnett and Hilary Ratner, 'Introduction: The Organization and Integration of Cognition and Emotion in Development', *Journal of Experimental Child Psychology* 67.1 (1997): 303–316.
 24. The theoretical and methodological reflections in this introduction all refer to Margrit Pernau and Imke Rajamani, 'Emotional Translations: Conceptual History Beyond Language', *History and Theory* 55.1 (2016): 46–65.
 25. *Clamator jacinobus*, known in Indian languages as the *chatak*. Three species of the cuckoo family are ubiquitous in monsoon reflections and have frequently been conflated or confused with each other, past and present. For the sake of clarity, they are: *Clamator jacinobus*, the *chatak* or pied-crested cuckoo who migrates to India on the monsoon winds and in legend only drinks raindrops; *Eudynamys scolopaceus*, the Asian *koel* or *koyal* (Skt. *kokila*) with its charcoal-black body; and the cousins *Hierococcyx varius* and *sparverioides*, the common and large hawk-cuckoos or *papiha*, whose cry '*piya! piya!*' sounds like 'my love!'
 26. See the chapter 'The Scent of Rain', in Cynthia Barnett, *Rain: A Natural and Cultural History* (New York: Crown Publishing, 2015), 210–226.
 27. Scheer, 'Are Emotions a Kind of Practice?'
 28. We thank Dipti Khera for sharing her research on lake palaces as a site for the celebration of monsoon feelings with us during the Monsoon Feelings conference at the Max Planck Institute for Human Development in June 2015.
 29. Used of both *Hierococcyx varius*, the common hawk-cuckoo or brain-fever bird, and its close cousin *Hierococcyx sparverioides*, or the large hawk-cuckoo.